

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Third World Quarterly

ISSN: 0143-6597 (Print) 1360-2241 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/ctwq20

The obscured racialisation of humanitarian design: imagined problem, imagined participation and imagined human

Mahmoud Keshavarz

To cite this article: Mahmoud Keshavarz (04 Sep 2025): The obscured racialisation of humanitarian design: imagined problem, imagined participation and imagined human, Third World Quarterly, DOI: 10.1080/01436597.2025.2547965

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2025.2547965

© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

Published online: 04 Sep 2025.

Submit your article to this journal

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=ctwq20

THIRD WORLD QUARTERLY
https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2025.2547965

OPEN ACCESS Check for updates

The obscured racialisation of humanitarian design: imagined problem, imagined participation and imagined human

Mahmoud Keshavarz

Department of Cultural Anthropology and Ethnology, Uppsala University, Uppsala, Sweden

ABSTRACT

Humanitarian design as a technological and aesthetic endeavour that has become part and parcel of contemporary humanitarianism promises to improve lives and bring dignity in the name of universal humanity through a wide spectrum of approaches, from expert-oriented problem solving to participatory and collaborative initiatives. However, decolonial thinkers who have questioned the universal positioning of the human, argue that the universal human of Western liberalism, human rights and ultimately humanitarianism, has always been and remains a Western white man. Against this background, I pose an important yet rarely considered question: Who is the human in humanitarian design? How is this human imagined by designers and their design solutions? How does the imagined human participate in the design process? Based on interviews with designers in Europe who work with humanitarian design projects for and with refugees in the Middle East, East Africa, and South Asia, I characterise and problematise three imaginary dimensions of humanitarian design: the imagined problem, the imagined participation, and the imagined human. I argue that designers reimagine these three dimensions in a way that feeds from and extends the existing racial injustices which leads to the obscuration of racialisation in and by humanitarian design.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 23 September 2024
Accepted 3 August 2025

KEYWORDS
Humanitarian design
racialisation
participation
humanitarianism
imaginary
colonialism

Introduction: uneven refugeeness

Fifteen years after the end of World War II, the last refugee camp in Europe was closed. Those camps were initially constructed to house people fleeing the Nazi regime, but subsequently accommodated people who had been freed from concentration camps after WWII (McConnachie 2016). As refugees returned to their home countries or gained citizenship and resettled elsewhere in the world, the camps were no longer needed as a temporary humanitarian solution to the political crisis of statelessness resulting from the nationalist and fascist projects of the time.

The histories of refugee camps across the Global South, however, are quite different. Many camps that emerged in the post-WWII period for the growing number of people being

CONTACT Mahmoud Keshavarz mahmoud.keshavarz@antro.uu.se
© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group
This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

displaced due to various colonial projects, such as the Indian Partition in 1947 or the creation of the state of Israel in 1948, still exist today. Refugee camps in the Global South continue to multiply and grow spatially and temporally, to the extent that the emergence and expansion of camps in regions such as South East Asia, the Middle East, Central America, or the Horn of Africa have been deemed a 'durable solution', a long-term home for displaced persons (Chimni 2004) whose mobility is tightly regulated and frequently restricted by violent border regimes (Agier 2011; McConnachie 2016; Pallister-Wilkins 2022a). Not only are they expanding in size and number, but they are also being equipped with new technologies and designs in the form of various relief items, products, and services through practices and discourses such as humanitarian design and innovation. How can one understand the disparity between the spatial and temporal experience of European refugees during and after WWII, and that of the many generations of refugees in the Global South?

The refugee camp – the example par excellence of humanitarianism and humanitarian design – is no longer a temporary solution as it was for European refugees during WWII, but rather the main and permanent space in which other humanitarian design solutions, including shelter, water, sanitation, energy supply, food distribution, identification, and banking, have been introduced and tested. As Eyal Weizman writes:

> Refugees, like all people escaping war and famine throughout history, make their way across borders into cities, or settle and construct new ones. Aid, if necessary, should follow them into these spaces rather than construct environments of total control to facilitate its delivery (Weizman 2011, 61).

It is important to remember that the role of humanitarianism in shaping the condition of displaced people in the Global South is deeply entangled with the global modern refugee regime. Scholars have shown how the modern refugee regime and humanitarian infrastructure of protection put in place between 1940 and 1950 have shaped much of the current conception of humanitarianism around the question of refugees (Gatrell 2013; Seuferling and Leurs 2021). Indeed, the infamous nexus of care and control as the emblem of the humanitarianism sector, identified by many anthropologists (Agier 2011; Fassin 2011; Malkki 1995; Ticktin 2011), is a product of interwar and post-war Europe. As Hannah Arendt succinctly put it: 'The world has created a new kind of human beings – the kind that are put in concentration camps by their foes and in internment camps by their friends' (1994, 110). However, my aim in this article is to examine the longevity of these mechanisms: how they are generated and sustained through practices such as humanitarian design, and how the temporal experience of refugeeness is extended through design interventions, contingent upon one's location within geopolitical and racial hierarchies. I am interested in understanding the inequality embedded in imagining which solutions are considered more urgent than others; in imagining which lives are considered worth living autonomously through mechanisms of rights and justice, and which lives are considered only as dependent on humanitarian design for generations to come.

Humanitarian design constitutes a specialised domain within the broader field of design, wherein designers engage collaboratively with, or are commissioned by, humanitarian organisations to develop products, services, or systems intended for populations affected by various forms of crisis or disaster. Humanitarian designers frequently characterise their practice as employing design methodologies to support individuals and communities in crisis in attaining conditions conducive to a dignified existence (Nielsen 2020, 98). However, in

practice, this defintion is far complex, as humanitarian design depends on institutional actors such as UNHCR, as well as commercial entities within the technology and logistics sectors (Pascucci 2021; Redfield 2012; Ziadah 2019). This network of practices and discourses has transformed well-intended individual design ideas into a discursive, technological and organisational framework aimed at generating sustainable and systemic solutions to the challenges that conventional humanitarian aid often addresses only temporarily and insufficiently (Escobar 2018). Within this discursive field, humanitarian designers frequently invoke normative concepts such as compassion, resilience, dignity, and empathy. These terms are mobilised to underscore the potential of design as a value-oriented practice that can substantively contribute to humanitarian efforts by translating abstract ethical principles into concrete, universally scalable and transportable applicable interventions (see Sandvik 2017).

Scholars have critiqued the work of humanitarian design and innovation for being a driving force in neoliberal restructuring of poor communities (Johnson 2011) and neoliberal reconfiguration of the development sector by turning into particular notions of innovation (Redfield 2018; Scott-Smith 2016), reproducing the violence of borders by ignoring border politics (Keshavarz 2020), and as a form of technocolonialism (Madianou 2019). Many of these works build on earlier critical accounts of humanitariansim and aid, where anthropologists have analysed humanitarianism, aid and development as an 'anti-politics machine' in which inherently political issues are reframed as technical problems to be solved through improved bureaucracy and technological means (Ferguson 1994); or how a form of 'will to improve' more than deliverance of aid is a governmental conduct in shaping populations based on certain norms and values (Li 2007). In such practices solutions to problems often reflect the values and norms of development actors more than those of the societies subject to development. Moreover, such depoliticisation and dehistoricisation of the context as well as the practice of aid, generates a 'moral economy of suffering' (Fassin 2011) where we witness a shift from rights to emotion by focusing only on alleviating suffering. Such reframing legitimises the aid based on recognition of suffering (Ticktin 2011) which in turn produces hierarchies between lives deemed more innocent and thus more worthy of saving than others, perpetuating inequality (Ticktin 2025). While I build on these critical accounts of humanitarian design in particular and humanitarianism in general, my intention here is different. I am interested in understanding what kind of imagination operates in the work of humanitarian designers that allows them to do this work despite all the critiques. In my conversations with the designers and similar to aid workers' perception of their profession's usefulness (Roth 2015; Smirk 2015), many of them showed some degree of awareness that their interventions are not the real political solutions to the calamities faced and experienced by displaced people; yet, they believed that their work does make a difference. More than that, they believed that the difference they make matters because it is not the same as the one often expressed by aid workers. Their presence is not the same as that of an aid worker, nor similar to a policy advocate or a distant hired designer. 'We are a bit of many different roles and actors within humanitarianism through our designs' said one of them, which seems to sit well with the narratives expressed by others I spoke with. This helps designers active in this field understand their work as useful and important. Most of the people I talked to have permanent jobs in humanitarian design firms or in other design firms as consultants in the humanitarian sector. This indicates that there is a strong market for humanitarian design ideas not only for the current frequent humanitarian crises, but also for the protracted refugeeness of the displaced people in the Global South.

In this article, I build on a series of narratives expressed by a group of designers based in Europe who have been active in the humanitarian sector for the last 15 years, designing different products and services for sanitation, water supply, shelter, food, energy, etc. for displaced refugees in the Global South who live in refugee camps. While humanitarian design has become a specific label of its own through the institutional work of design schools, design researchers, exhibitions, museums and organisations, not all the interviewees used the title of 'humanitarian designer' identifying instead as industrial or product designers working in the humanitarian sector. I conducted 10 interviews during 2020–21 with designers who were active in the field. My fieldwork plan was affected by COVID-19, and I did not have the opportunity to spend time at the designers' studios and offices as I had initially planned. Some of the interviews were held in-group and some individually. I met with a few of the designers more than once to follow up on our discussion. One designer had left the field and was active in another sector by the time of the interview. All the designers I interviewed were born, educated, and lived in Europe. To preserve the designers' anonymity and upon their request, I changed their names, and I do not disclose the kind of design projects they work on.

Based on the interviews, and in dialogue with Sylvia Wynter's work on the Western conception of humanity represented as the universal human, I show how particular processes of reimagination internal to the modern foundation of design practice render humanitarian design solutions necessary, useful and vital for certain people, despite recognising their political inefficiency. By reimagining the problem (refugeeness), the way it is addressed (participation), and for whom the solutions are provided (who is the human?), I show how the logic of humanitarian design obscures the question of race as a marker of differential positioning within the current unequal geopolitical distribution of wealth, rights and agency in the world. I understand race based on the work of Wynter (2003) not as a biological or fixed category, but a sociogenic construct: a product of historical, cultural, and epistemological processes that emerged with European colonialism and the rise of Western modernity. In this sense, race is a narrative construct that organises human difference in a particular way to serve specific political and economic purposes, especially under colonial capitalism (Wynter and McKittrick 2015).

While there is a considerable amount of scholarship on the question of race and racialisation within development (Kothari 2006; Pierre, 2020; Smith, Craney, and Roche 2024; White 2002; Wilson 2013), less attention has been paid to the ways in which race configures practices of humanitarianism. Among the few existing works, Adia Benton has focused on the racialised conception of risk in the work of humanitarianism (2016a) and how white supremacy shapes humanitarianism (2016b), while Polly Pallister-Wilkins has innovatively questioned the racialised conception of the universal human that justifies the ever-growing industry of humanitarianism (2021, 2022b). Scholars of humanitarianism have begun to address the issue of race, but the growing literature on humanitarian design has not yet grappled with the question of race. In taking up the task, I seek to understand how humanitarian designers manage to obscure the question of race by reimagining what is being designed, how it is designed, and for whom it is designed, in ways that make their work meaningful to themselves and in their view, meaningful to the world–yet ultimately perpetuate the unequal experiences of refugees who are differentially positioned within geopolitical and racial hierarchies.

The imagined problem: re-imagining problems through design's capacity

'It is not the idea that takes too much time, but the laborious time for planning all [the] unforeseen problems in collaboration with the partners. This means we have to spend a lot of time to make them understand what our vision is', says Sofia, a designer who joined a company developing humanitarian shelters a few years earlier. According to Sofia, much of her and her colleagues work time is spent not on designing, but rather on convincing humanitarian organisations why their particular idea works and why it should be implemented. This sense of confidence, of being sure their idea is the best one, has not always been there for Sofia and her colleagues: 'In the beginning we just wanted to design an open-source product and show it in a gallery, so humanitarian organisations could take it further. But our sponsor would only pay for something that will be used by those who need it'.

Humanitarian design can include a wide range of design solutions; from conceptual ideas and prototypes that win competitions but are never implemented, to products that are sold and delivered across the globe, whether they solve the problems they promise to solve or not. The designers I interviewed had never experienced any of the inhumane conditions they addressed. They had sketched ideas, talked to a limited number of people with previous experience of being refugees, and presented their ideas to humanitarian organisations, mostly the UNHCR. They created the first prototype in their office and tried it themselves be a cooking device or a shelter, but their first encounter with the reality of the use of their product was when it was implemented in a refugee camp to be used directly. Sofia and her colleagues mentioned that this encounter with reality was shocking and revealed the dysfunctionality of their ideas and imagination. Nevertheless, without it, they could not have refined their prototypes and ideas to address the many technical and functional failures. However, they believe that over time and through constant redesigning, their solutions have played an important part in the lives of refugees. As one of the designers articulated: '… many beneficiaries who use our product lived in a horrible condition before…'. This implies that the product created not only a relatively better condition, despite its many failures, but also rendered a previous reality that was, in the words of the designer, considered horrible prior to the arrival of the product.

Similar to Sofia's distinction between the quick work of ideation and the time-consuming work of planning and negotiating with partners, Michael, a head designer at a design firm, told me: 'It is not the products and designing that are the most difficult parts, the difficulty is to understand the political environment and also facing the reason why refugees live as refugees […] and it's not because of a lack of good technology or good design that refugees are in need of aid. Great design can do a lot, but it does not solve the problem'. While Michael indicated that he understands the limit of design solutions within the existing constraints, and that the real problem lies not within designing but elsewhere, he added that the UNHCR is very bad at defining the design problem: '…they only have a specific description of what kind of aid is needed and the standards for how that aid should be made available'. Michael refers to the UNHCR Core Relief Items Catalogue (2012) that describes the functions and technical details of different products from 'shelter items' such as tents to 'domestic items' such as kitchen sets, blankets and others. In another conversation, Michael also mentioned that the humanitarian sector's terms of operation are based on words indicating the lack of 'creativity' in the sector: 'Once we visualise our ideas and prototype them, it is much easier

to get them to accept our ideas. Discussing our ideas in words and on paper would never get us into any product out there'. Michael's observation reflects the private sector's prevailing narrative on innovation – a narrative that has frequently conflicted with the humanitarian sector's principled resistance to profit-oriented approaches and its structural reliance on public sector bureaucracies (Sandvik 2017). It is not surprising that designers often align with the private sector rather than public institutions as much of conventional industrial and product design education is based on the belief that design has a unique capacity to generate value for businesses, which has been advocated particularly in celebrated approaches such as 'design thinking'. While design discourse and practice have changed drastically in the last twenty years with a shift towards social rather than commercial ends, design thinking has nontheless remained pivotal in commercial, social and many approaches in between (see, for example, Brown 2009).

This is why after recognising the limits of design solutions and design's inability to respond to political conditions, Michael turned to recognising design's capacity to redefine the problem in a way that enables designers' ideas to be materialised and realised, acknowledging that with the help of the UNHCR's infrastructure and authority over refugees' lives, design ideas can become the solutions, bringing values that humanitarian organisations are not capable of cultivating on their own. What happens in these processes is a construction of different realities reserved for different kinds of expertise; a constant reimagining and redefining of politics as design, and ultimately a displacement of politics by design.

As a discourse and a discipline, design is often defined as a problem-solving endeavour. This definition has its origin in a specific Western imagined state of the world as a place for cybernetic configuration of the technical condition (Hayles 1999). I have previously discussed this definition as a practice that sees the world's complexity and heterogeneities as a set of 'wicked problems' that can be modelled in order to be solved by design's specific knowledge regimes and tools such as sketching, visualisation, brainstorming, work-shopping, post-it ideation, prototyping, modelling, user scenarios, user testing, and machine learning (Keshavarz 2023). In dialogue with the notion of 'social imaginary' (Taylor 2004), I have called this the 'design imaginary of problem-solving', which is produced as much by the commercial trope of Silicon Valley innovation heroes as it is by European social innovation labs and participatory design that argue for socially driven design over profit-driven activities. This imagination generates a future in which designers' skills play a central role. A future that, without designers' skills looks horrible or catastrophic.

In the context of shelter, Agier (2011) has argued that refugee protection has come to be understood as a 'mere problem of residence' (16). Furthermore, as clearly indicated by Herscher and Monk (2021), what we witness today is a 'global shelter imaginary', where the current humanitarian governance of third world subjects manages a temporary space of rightlessness and placelessness by substituting the problem of *rights* with that of *dignity* and the problem of *refugee* with that of *refuge*. The involvement of humanitarian design is therefore imperative, considering how it can render these political questions into material ones. I am not suggesting that materialisation has no politics. Alongside many other scholars, I have argued that the world and its possibilities of access to, inhabiting in, and moving through it as matters of politics are articulated through design practices (Costanza-Chock 2020; Fry 2010; Keshavarz 2019). What I am suggesting here is that by ignoring 'the politics of design and the design of politics' (Keshavarz 2019), humanitarian design becomes a space for reimagining political problems as problems that can be addressed only by design's

capacity. This displacement of politics is similar, yet different from seeing aid as an anti-politics machine, as expressed by earlier critiques of humanitarianism. What designing enables through its specific language of visuals, prototyping, use and problem-solving is the legitimisation of design as 'the' only qualified agent in addressing the problem. This authoritative and monopolising effect of design solutions on reimagining what can possibly be done is quite specific to design's particular qualities and affordances as an added-value generating activity. Through such reimagination, the engagement with the conditions of refugees is presented only as a matter of technique and aesthetics, function and form, utility and usability. These are matters that for a long time have formed an epistemological lexicon in design as an apolitical grammar of engagement with the world (Rosner 2018). Thus, the reimagination at work here pushes politics out and lets design enter in a way that keeps the two as separated as possible. The humanitarian designers I interviewed were aware of the political aspects of the living conditions of refugees, and seemed concerned about their capacity and the relevance of their skills to improve those conditions. As Albin put it, 'Anyone understands that what we designed is much better than what they had before. But is it enough? No'. Again, Albin's reflection points to the inadequacy of design, yet positions it as an agent in bringing a relatively better condition. This might be similar to the general logic of humanitarianism when legitimisation is achieved through the discourse of 'good-enough' aid. Yet, there is something particular about design. Design, compared to other forms of aid, tends to encapsulate the complex problem into a single product or service, stretching the problem through constant redesigning and believing that its insufficiencies can be refined with another, better design, as Sofia had explained earlier. Thus, the motto of modern design as 'devising courses of action aimed at changing existing situations into preferred ones' by Simon (1969), one of the early figures of cybernetics, reflects the ways in which problems can be prolonged through the involvement of design.

While mindful of the limits of their design solution, designers manage to address the persistence of the problem by reimagining it in technical isolation driven by the logic of preferred conditions that recognise only better aesthetics, better utility, better function, better production, better distribution, and better customer service as aspects separated from the unequal condition. The logic of better condition, distinct from the notion of 'good-enough,' may sound like a neutral measure, but it carries a specific history as a universal conception. Wynter (1996), in her critique of what she calls a 'telos of development', describes how a racialised conception of the Global South subject produced in a state of debt is always positioned to be redeemed through 'material redemption' (301). Material redemption, as enacted through Western technology and design, reimagines the problem by defining humanity in specific terms – such as rationality and productivity– as illustrated when Albin states, 'anyone understands that what we designed is much better than what they had before'. Yet it is not enough and another better design will provide a far better condition. There is an imagined end in these reiterative processes of designing that remains unarticulated in the designers' words.

Not only Albin but also several other designers I spoke with expressed similar tension in their work: recognising the limits of design, yet embracing design's unlimited ability to generate a better version of the previous design. This contradiction is not about inconsistencies between discourse and practice, but rather part and parcel of how complex problems are imagined within contemporary design work in general and humanitarian design in particular. This contradiction can also be understood through the discursive shift in legitimising the

presence of Western powers in the Global South in the postcolonial era. For example, in the context of urban planning and architecture, postcolonial development plans often continued late colonial development (Levin 2022). This continuity, however, had to be reimagined from the 'not yet civilised' approach that characterised colonial rule. This approach imagines colonies as places devoid of science, innovation, and culture, as their imagined inferior inhabitants are a threat to or unable to join the project of civilisation (Kothari and Wilkinson 2010):

> With the emergence of 'development' as an object of modernization theory following World War II, inherent causes, whether environmental or racial, could no longer explain 'backwardness' and legitimize the perpetuation of external rule. The new developmental narrative postulated latecomers' ability 'to catch up', and thereby align themselves with 'universal history' as recorded and narrated by the West, via the omnipotence of science and technology, rational economic planning, and social engineering (Levin 2022, 5).

Thus, civilisation, as it is defined by Western modernity and the telos of development, could be that unarticulated end for never-ending iterative design solutions. This reconfigures short-term, emergency relief items into everlasting redesigning. The imagined problem is reimagined insofar as it continues to generate more, better designs, which will never reach the final end of Western modernity. In such a context, designers have relied on participatory design traditions that emerged in the 1960s in Scandinavian countries. While these participatory design methods share similar aims with the participatory development agenda in post-war Europe, they differ in their methods and produce different outcomes. Through participatory methods, designers have collaborated with the 'end-users' or 'beneficiaries' because, within a liberal postcolonial conditionit, it is believed that they should have a say in the designs that affect them. The question, however, is: To what extent is that participation also framed and staged, and, more specifically, imagined through specific material and discursive design practices? I address this in the next section.

The imagined participation: reimagining the Northern designer vs the Southern bricoleur

'When users talk about a problem, it does not mean that they know the solution', Albin claimed in his interview. When I asked him what he meant, he clarified that their products in the hands of users face unforeseen problems that the designers had not anticipated. The users often ask their support team to find solutions to the new problems. But, Albin adds, 'after so many years we have gained a lot of experience and can say: "oh you want this feature in the product, but is it not better that you build this locally?"' What Albin and his colleagues promote here is what many in the aid sector call 'capacity building'. By refusing to design a new solution and instead guiding users to find their own solution, the designers, in their view, promote a democratic culture in their design processes. This is often used as a response to the critiques that accuse humanitarian design of a paternalistic top-down problem-solving approach. Albin and his colleagues argue that they started their work with the hope and vision of what they refer to as 'resilient communities' – a notion that, according to them, would situate their design more as a platform, a structure that 'beneficiaries' could build on, according to the local culture and materials, and as defined by their needs. While designers get most of their revenue from 'expert-developed' designs, they are also invested in more participatory ideas that focus on capacity building.

However, the idea of building capacity in the Global South is not as innocuous as it may seem. Nolan (2021), in her study of the intimate relations between racial science and twentieth century design, shows how 'the burgeoning field of technohumanitarianism served as a supplement to structural adjustment programs (SAPs), providing consumer products (at a cost) to fill the vacuum in social services that SAPs created in many states in the global south' (179). More specifically, in one of her cases, Nolan discusses the work of Yona Friedman, an architect who had devoted much of his work in the 1960s and 1970s to what could be considered architecture for development by designing and prototyping housing units that could be adjusted by the inhabitants. His idea of 'mobile architecture', Nolan writes, 'points to the discursive construction of a new type of subject in the global south, one now familiar in the age of late-capitalist humanitarianism but still quite novel in the 1960s and '70s: that of the resilient bricoleur' (110). Nolan argues that the idea of a Southern bricoleur as the third world subject, an adaptive entrepreneur who does not need help other than 'self-help', was inspired by Claude Lévi-Strauss's structuralist understanding of humans in the Global South. According to Lévi-Strauss, the Southern bricoleur, compared to the Northern engineer, lacks an understanding of design and planning and instead works with a repertoire of what is available. This local work of configuration is limited, and thus '*has to* use this repertoire […] whatever the task at hand, because it *has nothing else* at its disposal' (Lévi-Strauss 1966, 17, emphasis mine). Wynter (1996) reminds us that the human of Western modernity was constructed by constructing an imaginary of lack. This means that Black, Indigenous and poor populations in the colonised parts of the world were imagined as lacking what could be attained through the telos of Western modernity, civilisation and development. And the conditions of lack and debt varied across different times and places throughout the world.

This particular Global South subject is thus imagined in this participatory framework of humanitarianism, aid, and development as one who, with some guidance, can unleash their creativity. 'I have not been in Afghanistan, but I can help people by pointing to the right direction so they can find a better solution', said Albin in one of the interviews. In this scenario, the Global North designers do not lose their meaning and relevance despite the idea that the users design their own solution. They are more of a facilitator; someone who, with their universal expertise and perspective, can guide different users of humanitarian products in the Global South to find their own solutions. This clear distinction between the creative skills of people in different geographical locations has a historical racial trajectory. As Iskander (2021) reminds us skill defines the capacity for freedom of those who are described as unskilled in the need to learn certain skills to achieve their freedom.

However, the tension between expert-oriented and participatory design is not as binary as many contemporary design approaches suggest. In fact, humanitarian designers navigate and negotiate this dualistic space. This became evident, for example, in Michael's reaction to my question about how designers work with the particular needs of their users, and whether they risk imagining a user who does not exist in reality if they do not make their projects fully participatory. Michael defended their way of working by criticising those designers who do a good job of participatory design but are not able to scale up their ideas to meet the urgent demands of humanitarian crises:

> We produce for 10,000 users per month and there is no way to involve all of them […] They live in a terrible condition and their condition will be improved with these products. So, the scale of production and distribution for us is above everything else […] when we started to work,

> there were around 42 million displaced people and now [it] is around 84 million […] When we can, we work with capacity building and resilience but we cannot invest all the money in resilience and capacity building […] our design is about scale and impact and we are proud of it despite all [the] critique.

Depending on the project and on the impact and scale the designers and their humanitarian partners envision, humanitarian designers always work with both approaches – a rational, planned, studio-based developed idea, combined with a field visit as well as participatory workshops with a handful of humanitarian workers and practitioners and a few end users or beneficiaries. Thus, whenever necessary, humanitarian designers can bring forward the slow, complex, and participatory aspect of their work, and if this approach is not suitable, for instance when funders want to see quick, large-scale impact, they can use the efficient, scaled, impactful principles developed by designers. This tension between the two approaches, rather than a contradiction, is not unique to the designers I talked to. It is indeed part and parcel of a participatory logic within humanitarianism and development sector. Andrea Cornwall (2008) has previously identified the ambiguity of the concept of participation and its uncritical use and deployment as inherently 'empowering' within the development sector. Ranging from manipulative or tokenistic to transformative and empowering, she argues that participation is a contested and context-driven practice with its origin in colonial administration (Cornwall 2006) which carries different meanings to different actors. Hence, the forms and scales of participation matter as much as their intent. Furthermore, Kelty (2020) shows in his genealogy of the figure of the participant in different sectors including the development sector, the tension between expertise and a participatory mindset is most explicit in the main protagonist of participatory development: the tool kit. The participatory tool kit by nature is evidence of a 'desire for local, radical, highly context-specific forms of participatory liberation, and at the same time a desire to scale up such participation and spread it around the globe, wherever it might be needed' (194). The participatory toolkit differs from other forms of kits used within humanitarianism (see, for example, Redfield 2013). While the former is specifically designed to be used as tools for generating communication and enabling the expression of needs, concerns, and ideas among aid-receiving communities, the latter is more of a tool box facilitating the work of aid practitioners efficiently and quickly while encapsulating humanitarianisms norms and values. The participatory toolkit often includes a series of visuals, materials, instructions and open-ended questions and scenarios designed to help users express thier problems, needs and desires–visually, textually or performatively, and even design their own solutions. These toolkits, as necessary devices of humanitarian design and design thinking are often represented in the forms of method cards. The cards can be seen as material artifacts that primarily generate a sense of participation mostly for the designers themselves (Ansari 2019; Keshavarz 2023). The kind of participation imagined by these toolkits becomes participation that is only mediated through the toolkit. In a sense, what participates the most is the toolkit and the imagination that has designed it and envisioned its operation in any context and any place in the world. The experience of participation generated through these method cards and toolkits, which both empowers Global South subjects and unleashes their creativity and produces data for Global North designers, can be seen as a form of pseudo-ethnography that is not about understanding the world from the viewpoint of its inhabitants, but aims to produce anecdotal evidence

for legitimising a point of persuasion. As anthropologist Maia Green (2010) writes in the context of participation and development in Tanzania:

> As combinations of organisational form and specialised practices deemed to generate participatory effects, participatory approaches in development are neither method nor organisation but mobile institutions, travelling technologies of the social, which can be instantiated in any place at any time to produce their anticipated outputs. These take the form of the reports and prioritisations which can be translated into project plans and budgets to be enacted at different scales (1245).

Participation within humanitarian design is thus imagined through specific visual and material technologies of generating an experience of participation for the designers. By framing and staging participation (Keshavarz and Maze 2013) as part of the remedy to the imagined problem, humanitarian designers not only legitimise their work through ideas such as capacity building and democratic designing; they can also imagine themselves and the users of their designs as part of a community where differences matter less than similarities. When the humanitarian designers I met were confronted with my question of how they deal with particularities and differences of different contexts when their universal and scaled-up design methods and structures are extracted from participatory models, they all agreed that there are differences between contexts and users but even greater similarities. When I asked what those similarities are, most of the designers pointed to what they considered to be universal human needs: drinking clean water, having access to proper meals and a basic energy supply, having a place to rest, having privacy, etc. This resonates particularly well with Wynter's analysis of how Western humanity represented itself as the universal human by projecting a 'space of otherness' in the first stage through documenting and presenting 'phenotypical and religio-cultural differences between human variations and/or population groups' (Wynter 2003, 296) as the basis for the separability of human beings (da Silva 2016). In the second stage, however, these differences were obscured in terms of race and other social markers that positioned colonised populations of the world as lacking and in need of redemption, yet ultimately 'to be defined in terms of degrees of rational perfection/imperfection' (Wynter 2003, 296) in relation to a universal model of humanity.

Thus, the outcomes of humanitarian design developed partly through the expertise of designers in the Global North and partly by the adaptation skills of the resilient Global South bricoleur are an articulation of an imagined community that is bound by an imagined figure: the universal human.

The imagined human: reimagining the average human of the middle ground

Michael, Albin, Sofia, and their respective colleagues believed that for humanitarian design to be successful and have the required impact as defined by aid workers and organisations, there needs to be a 'middle ground'. This middle ground cannot be imagined solely by the designer, but should equally be an outcome of participation. This means that the imagined participant of humanitarian design is knowledgeable about their local context, but it is the Global North designer who has the holistic view and is able to connect different bodies of local knowledge extracted from the Middle East, South Asia, Central Africa, and South America in order to find the 'middle ground' that can form the base for everyone in the world to build on. From this perspective, it is not that the Global South participant does not have

any capacity or skill, as this would render participation meaningless, but that their capacity or skill are limited and partial and are only part of the bigger schematic of the design that humanitarian designers could rework into a universal structure. This mechanism of differentiation between the different participants of a humanitarian design project, some of them considered universal designers and some local bricoleurs, requires further examination.

Once the unequal distribution of resources between the Global South and the Global North is reimagined as a problem that can be addressed by design's capacity, the involvement of 'those with problems' in finding a solution can also be reimagined as participation. But neither of these two main practices is possible without imagining a general or universal conception of the figure of the human. Oscar, who has been active in commercial and business product design and development for many years before joining the humanitarian sector, has a clear image of the vague figuration of 'the middle ground'. He explains:

> In [a] business strategy plan you do not want to be in the middle. You want to be either the cheapest, the fastest, the most effective, or you want to be the best and most exclusive. But in the humanitarian context you need to be in the middle.

He adds that 'our product has its shortcomings but compared to what UNHCR were providing before it is much better. It is not a silver bullet solution but the best compromise solution. It is not best at anything but better in many aspects'. The middle ground approach in humanitarian design to respond to differences and complexities of contexts, lives, and conditions of people who are subject to humanitarianism is based on the assumption of a universal human figure. But this universal human is not a sum of the social, cultural, economic, and historical differences people embody. It is an imagined universal humanity that has its origin in the Renaissance conception of the human, as well as other historical and political forces. For example, Glasman (2019) introduces the concept of 'minimal humanity', which refers to an imagined form of humanity shaped by the quantification and standardisation of humanitarian practices. This concept reflects a historical and political reconfiguration of human needs, reducing life to its most basic, measurable elements – such as calories, litres of water, and square metres of shelter. Furthermore, the design and architecture of the twentieth century were shaped around the notion of a universal human as an average human body posed as universal but imagined according to particular gendered, classed, abled and racialised norms around bodily shapes and orientation, as pointed out by scholars of gender, queer and disability studies (see, for example, Hamraie 2017). At the same time, the average human of humanitarian design also embodies a specific norm and imaginary, one that is bound by the basic needs defined by humanitarian ideals: shelter, food, sanitation, etc., as frequently referred to by the humanitarian designers I talked to.

None of the designers I spoke with described the users of their design as people with particular gender, class, race or other social and historical categories of difference and exclusion. They mostly talked about 'the human' in commonsensical terms, using formulations like 'basic human needs', 'universal human needs', 'everyone understands what the most important human needs are' etc. However, the absence of race in the narrative, I argue, points to a broader obscuration of racial difference in humanitarian design. To understand such absence, Sylvia Wynter's lifelong project of deconstructing the hegemonic Western conception of the human which dominates our previous, current, and future understanding of humanity, is helpful. The human in Wynter's writing is linked to two figures she calls Man1 and Man2. Wynter argues that Man1 is invented by the Renaissance as homo politicus,

'differentiated but not wholly separate from the homo religious conception of human that was tethered to the theological order of knowledge of pre-Renaissance Latin-Christian medieval Europe' (Wynter and McKittrick 2015, 10). Man1 prefigured Man2, a figure based on 'the Western bourgeoisie's model of being human that has been articulated as, since the latter half of the nineteenth century, liberal monohumanism's *homo oeconomicus*' (ibid). These figures emerge from but also shape a dominant knowledge system that explains who and what humans are through producing racialised categories of 'the rational and irrational, the selected and dysselected, the haves and have-nots as asymmetrical naturalised racial-sexual groupings that are specific to time, place and personhood' (ibid). This historical and culture-specific imagined figure of human that thrives on extracting and accumulating through 'overrepresentation of (white bourgeois) Man' (Wynter 2003, 260), presumes to be universal for all human beings to which all lives are subordinated. This imagined human is nonetheless real and the differentiations and subordinations it produces, do not disappear by any assumed commitment to all human life as it is claimed by liberal humanism. The imagined problems and the designed solutions are thus considered 'actions taken for the sake of the well-being of [the universal human] referent model [which] continue to be perceived as if they were being taken for the sake of the human-in-general' (Wynter 1995, 43). The middle ground design solutions are therefore not only derived from an imagined universal human, but also produce middle ground average users of the product through normative, Western assumptions about their needs.

The inequalities addressed by humanitarian design through imagining the middle ground user resonate with a liberal moral logic, in the sense of accepting inequality as either a temporary state or the result of an individual's private failure and never as a structural condition (Redfield 2012, 458). This is reflected in Michael's musings about the way people have no choice but to use their humanitarian design products: 'Nobody wants this product as the real thing to be used, no one voluntarily chooses life with these products, we know that, but you also see that some people continue their lives with this, try to make something out of it'. This means that in the absence of a self-chosen life, those products temporarily address the inequality, and in this way can, to some degree, grant some relief despite the constraints.

Reid-Henry (2014, 425) argues that humanitarianism is a form of 'liberal diagnostic' that serves to identify and characterise problems, through which its designation implies the framing of solutions. While this is true of humanitarian design in general, yet the specific practice of design –entangled with market forces, profit motives, iterative improvement, and an individualsitic notion of user and use– inevitably materialises what Lauren Williams has rightly called a 'rapid privatisation of problems that properly belong to the public' (2019, 314). This neo-liberal configuration, driven by many design practices including humanitarian design, has paved the way for a seemingly liberal colour-blind society where designers engage in projects that promise equality beyond race, but in practice capitalise on racial injustices while obscuring race and racism as structural problems of capitalism.

Mills's (1997) conception of racism as a social contract is helpful here. Mills argues that racial categories have been central to the fiction of the 'social contract' structuring much of our liberal understanding of how justice can be distributed equally. Mills contends that the universal foundation of the social contract is only a myth and is deeply racialised. He shows how race and racism shape fundamental ideas about humanity, democracy, and political subjectivity. The racial division that shapes these ideas rests upon the imaginaries that have

turned into the 'truth' through the imagined human (Man1 and Man2), in which non-whites were not capable of authority and governance. This resonates with what Jemima Pierre (2020) calls 'the racial vernacular of development', where racial differences established and legitimised by racial capitalism continue to dominate the practice and scholarship of development and humanitarianism. This process is a historical one, entangled with the project of colonialism and liberalism in the West (Pallister-Wilkins 2022b), where 'a genuine concern for the suffering of others came to be treated as a problem of order and value more generally' (Reid-Henry 2014, 419). Humanitarian design, in this sense, is truly a liberal project that claims to stand for equality and justice for all, where 'all' is reduced to Man1 and Man2. Furthermore, and in the absence of enduring equality as the permanent condition of the world, limited, temporary 'equality' materialised in measurable concrete designs can be granted as believed by Michael evident in his reflection about that the only better choice for beneficiaries is to use their product.

Following Mill's critique of racial liberalism (2017), I am not suggesting that humanitarian design as a liberal project of modernity is racist, but rather that it is racially biased by reimagining the average human, its problems, and its participation in a way that does not acknowledge racial justice as its main drive, and obscures historical racial domination and the legacy of structural white domination. Said (1989) has spoken of imagined geographies, where spaces are imagined and thus represented in a way that makes various actions possible and legitimate. Having the means to take those actions – to design – renders these imaginaries real. For Said, the geographic imagination is the operating apparatus of cultural imperialism, where certain meanings are ascribed to certain places and situations and certain knowledge is produced about them. It is through such imaginaries that certain courses of action become possible in relation to a specific place, helping certain groups in society to participate in the imagination and production of meanings. It is by imagining a universal human and making this figure the subject of particular design products or services that race can be ignored while particular human categories are produced: those deemed to require special forms of design to regain their 'humanity' as imagined within humanitarian design.

Final remarks: when imagined presents limit imaginative futures

In this article, I have focused on the question of race in my analysis of humanitarian design by discussing three particular processes of reimagination. First, political problems addressed by humanitarian design projects are reimagined as problems that can be addressed only by designers' particular expertise, skills, and capacities, thereby prolonging design's relevance through a logic of continuous improvement. Second, the problem of top-down expertise is reimagined as a problem of participation, oscillating between expert-oriented design and the local adoption of skills. Third, the problem of human differences–both assigned and embodied– is reimagined by designing a solution with and for a universal human devoid of gendered, classed and racial differences that position people differently and unequally in different parts of the world and history. These three shifts in imagination seem to be necessary for humanitarian designers to be able to operate and navigate the contradictions between a theoretical understanding of the inadequacy of humanitarian design solutions and the practical demand for designing a 'good compromise', as put by one of the designers I interviewed. Scholars have argued that humanitarian designers believe in the capacity of the small to generate 'macro effects', in 'little development' rather than a big intervention or major infrastructural change

(Collier et al. 2017; Ojani, 2023). Yet, many of the designers I talked to argued that their designs are neither about small-scale nor large-scale interventions, but about defining a middle ground to achieve greater impact which could serve different people around the world by addressing what they described as common universal needs such as shelter, water, sanitation, etc. This means that humanitarian designers are not as humble as Redfield (2018) suggests in accepting their limited impact, nor are they as revolutionary radicals as proponents of the idea claim (Pilloton 2009). Rather, they occupy the blurry space of the middle ground, a space that can become real only through reimagining what, how, and who is addressed by their designs. This is a space devoid of histories of racial differences and geopolitical inequalities, which enables humanitarian designers to continue their work despite all contradictions, tensions, and critiques.

If we follow the insight of Ruth Wilson Gilmore that 'freedom is a place' (2022, 474), then what humanitarian designers do by imagining, articulating, and materialising a middle ground is to alienate those inhabiting particular places and histories. Humanitarian designers reimagine those places in the political structure of the world by redesigning people's environments in a particular way, such that only certain designed products and certain forms of participation promise and provide equal lives. This reimagination is a deeply racial work, a continuation of the European project of the production of differences by means of racialisation. As I have shown, not only is humanitarian design's work of imagination shaped by a foundational ignorance of racial differences embedded within the project of modernity and consequently modern design; through its imagined solutions and participation in the world, humanitarian design also obscures racism and thus perpetuates the structure of white supremacy and its harmful role in confining possible imaginations for a more egalitarian future.

The critiques of humanitarian design are often accused of being idealistic or utopian as expressed at times by the designers I talked to. A utopian and idealistic position is often placed in opposition to a pragmatic or realistic approach, with the former considered merely fantasy or imagination, compared to the grounded methods of the latter. I have tried to show, however, that the realistic position also builds on invisible imagination work that pushes and shrinks the space for building other collective imaginations. The task is to show that what we experience today as pragmatic solutions are articulations of specific imaginations, and that other imaginations–based on other understandings of human–could have taken place if they were not dismissed or marginalised by being characterised, at best, as utopian and unrealistic and at worst, as uncivilised and culturally limited. Humanitarian design, as a clear, tangible and concrete imaginative work of humanitarian reason, is a case in point for understanding how certain imaginaries are realised and materialised by obfuscating racial differentiation, making certain agency invisible, limiting the space for other imaginations to take place, and articulating a future while disarticulating possibilities for other futures.

Ethical approval

Participants in the study have given their verbal consent. Due to pseudonymization of personal and professional data the participants are not identifiable in this article.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

Funding

The study was funded by the Swedish Government Research Council for sustainable development, Formas, with grant number: FR-2019-00669.

Acknowledgements

I would like to thank the editors of the special issue, Laura Nkula-Wenz and Tania Messell, for their generous invitation to think with them and others through the form of this paper, as well as for their invaluable supports and comments throughout the process. I am also grateful to the two anonymous reviewers for their insightful suggestions, which helped sharpen my argument and clarify the paper's positioning and contribution. This study was part of the research project 'PLACED: Accommodating refugees and asylum seekers and the spatial production of hospitality and otherness'. I extend my thanks to my colleagues in the project, Erling Björgvinsson and Kristina Gränge, for their thoutghful input in shaping and defining the project conceptually and theoretically. In a later stages, I benefited from the generous comments of many colleagues and friends: Chakad Ojani, Sofi Jansson-Keshavarz, Sverker Finnström, Ana Chiritoiu, Charlotta Widmark, Carl Rommel and other colleagues at the Department of Cultural Anthropology and Ethnology at Uppsala University, whose insights contributed meaningfully to the development of this paper.

Notes on contributor

Mahmoud Keshavarz is Associate Professor of Cultural Anthropology at Uppsala University, Sweden. His work addresses the role of materiality, technology, and designing in mobility, migration, and bordering with a particular focus on the question of race, colonialism, and coloniality. He is author of *The Design Politics of the Passport: Materiality, Immobility, and Dissent* (Bloomsbury 2019) and co-editor of *Seeing Like a Smuggler: Borders from Below* (Pluto Press 2021).

ORCID

Mahmoud Keshavarz http://orcid.org/0000-0001-8934-988X

Data availability statement

The participants of this study did not give written consent for their data to be shared publicly, and as such the supporting data is not available.

References

Agier, M. 2011. *Managing the Undesirables: Refugee Camps and Humanitarian Government*. Cambridge: Polity Press.

Ansari, A. 2019. "Global Methods, Local Designs." In *The Social Design Reader*, edited by E. Resnick, 417–430. London: Bloomsbury.

Arendt, H. 1994. "We Refugees." In *Altogether Elsewhere: Writers on Exile*, edited by M. Robinson, 110–119. New York: Harvest.

Benton, A. 2016a. "Risky Business: Race, Nonequivalence and the Humanitarian Politics of Life." *Visual Anthropology* 29 (2): 187–203. https://doi.org/10.1080/08949468.2016.1131523.

Benton, A. 2016b. "African Expatriates and Race in the Anthropology of Humanitarianism." *Critical African Studies* 8 (3): 266–277. https://doi.org/10.1080/08949468.2016.1131523.

Brown, T. 2009. *Change by Design: How Design Thinking Transforms Organizations and Inspires Innovation*. New York: Harper Collins.
Chimni, B. S. 2004. "From Resettlement to Involuntary Repatriation: Towards a Critical History of Durable Solutions to Refugee Problems." *Refugee Survey Quarterly* 23 (3): 55–73. https://doi.org/10.1093/rsq/23.3.55.
Collier, S. J., J. Cross, P. Redfield, and A. Street. 2017. "Little Development Devices/Humanitarian Goods." Special issue, *Limn*, No. 9.
Cornwall, A. 2006. "Historical Perspectives on Participation in Development." *Commonwealth & Comparative Politics* 44 (1): 62–83. https://doi.org/10.1080/14662040600624460.
Cornwall, A. 2008. "Unpacking 'Participation': Models, Meanings and Practices." *Community Development Journal* 43 (3): 269–283. https://doi.org/10.1093/cdj/bsn010.
Costanza-Chock, S. 2020. *Design Justice: Community-Led Practices to Build the Worlds We Need*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press.
da Silva, D. F. 2016. "On Difference without Separability." In *32a São Paulo Art Biennial–Incerteza Viva'*, edited by J. Volz and J. Rebouças, 57–65. São Paulo: Fundação Bienal de São Paulo.
Escobar, A. 2018. *Designs for the Pluriverse: Radical Interdependence, Autonomy, and the Making of Worlds*. Durham: Duke University Press.
Fassin, D. 2011. *Humanitarian Reason: A Moral History of the Present*. Berkeley: University of California Press.
Ferguson, J. 1994. *Anti-Politics Machine: Development, Depoliticization, and Bureaucratic Power in Lesotho*. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press.
Fry, T. 2010. *Design as Politics*. London: Berg.
Gatrell, P. 2013. *The Making of the Modern Refugee*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
Glasman, J. 2019. *Humanitarianism and the Quantification of Human Needs: Minimal Humanity*. Abingdon: Routledge.
Green, M. 2010. "Making Development Agents: Participation as Boundary Object in International Development." *Journal of Development Studies* 46 (7): 1240–1263. https://doi.org/10.1080/00220388.2010.487099.
Hamraie, A. 2017. *Building Access: Universal Design and the Politics of Disability*. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press.
Hayles, N. K. 1999. *How We Became Posthuman: Virtual Bodies in Cybernetics, Literature and Information*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
Herscher, A., and D. B. Monk. 2021. *The Global Shelter Imaginary: IKEA Humanitarianism and Rightless Relief*. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press.
Iskander, N. 2021. *Does Skill Make Us Human? Migrant Workers in 21st-Century Qatar and Beyond*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
Johnson, C. G. 2011. "The Urban Precariat, Neoliberalization, and the Soft Power of Humanitarian Design." *Journal of Developing Societies* 27 (3-4): 445–475. https://doi.org/10.1177/0169796X1102700409.
Kelty, C. M. 2020. *The Participant: A Century of Participation in Four Stories*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
Keshavarz, M. 2019. *The Design Politics of the Passport: Materiality, Immobility, and Dissent*. London: Bloomsbury Publishing.
Keshavarz, M. 2020. "Violent Compassions: Humanitarian Design and the Politics of Borders." *Design Issues* 36 (4): 20–32. https://doi.org/10.1162/desi_a_00611.
Keshavarz, M. 2023. "Design: The Colonial Imaginary of Humanitarian Good (s)." In *The Routledge International Handbook of Critical Philanthropy and Humanitarianism*, edited by K. Mitchell and P. Pallister-Wilkins, 135–144. London: Routledge.
Keshavarz, M., and R. Maze. 2013. "Design and Dissensus: Framing and Staging Participation in Design Research." *Design Philosophy Papers* 11 (1): 7–29. https://doi.org/10.2752/089279313X13968799815994.
Kothari, U. 2006. "An Agenda for Thinking about 'Race' in Development." *Progress in Development Studies* 6 (1): 9–23. https://doi.org/10.1191/1464993406ps124oa.

Kothari, U., and R. Wilkinson. 2010. "Colonial Imaginaries and Postcolonial Transformations: Exiles, Bases, Beaches." *Third World Quarterly* 31 (8): 1395–1412. https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2010.538239.

Levin, A. 2022. *Architecture and Development: Israeli Construction in Sub-Saharan Africa and the Settler Colonial Imagination, 1958-1973*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Lévi-Strauss, C. 1966. *The Savage Mind: The Nature of Human Society*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Li, T. M. 2007. *The Will to Improve: Governmentality, Development, and the Practice of Politics*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Madianou, M. 2019. "Technocolonialism: Digital Innovation and Data Practices in the Humanitarian Response to Refugee Crises." *Social Media + Society* 5 (3): 1–13. https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305119863146.

Malkki, L. H. 1995. "Refugees and Exile: From 'Refugee Studies' to the National Order of Things." *Annual Review of Anthropology* 24 (1): 495–523. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.an.24.100195.002431.

McConnachie, K. 2016. "Camps of Containment: A Genealogy of the Refugee Camp." *Humanity: An International Journal of Human Rights, Humanitarianism, and Development* 7 (3): 397–412. https://doi.org/10.1353/hum.2016.0022.

Mills, C. W. 1997. *The Racial Contract*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Mills, C. W. 2017. *Black Rights/White Wrongs: The Critique of Racial Liberalism*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Nielsen, B. F. 2020. "Humanitarian Design." In *Humanitarianism: Keywords*, edited by A. De Lauri, 97–99. Leiden: Brill.

Nolan, G. 2021. *Savage Mind to Savage Machine: Racial Science and Twentieth-Century Design*. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press.

Ojani, C. 2023. "Smallness and Small-Device Heuristics." *Social Anthropology/anthropologie Sociale* 31 (2): 39–53. https://doi.org/10.3167/saas.2023.310204.

Pallister-Wilkins, P. 2021. "Saving the Souls of White Folk: Humanitarianism as White Supremacy." *Security Dialogue* 52 (1_suppl): 98–106. https://doi.org/10.1177/09670106211024419.

Pallister-Wilkins, P. 2022a. *Humanitarian Borders: Unequal Mobility and Saving Lives*. London: Verso Books.

Pallister-Wilkins, P. 2022b. "HuManitarianism: Race and the Overrepresentation of 'Man'." *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 47 (3): 695–708. https://doi.org/10.1111/tran.12531.

Pascucci, E. 2021. "Refugee Shelter in a Logistical World: Designing Goods for Supply-Chain Humanitarianism." *Antipode* 53 (1): 260–278. https://doi.org/10.1111/anti.12680.

Pierre, J. 2020. "The Racial Vernaculars of Development: A View from West Africa." *American Anthropologist* 122 (1): 86–98. https://doi.org/10.1111/aman.13352.

Pilloton, E. 2009. "Introduction: Design Can Change the World." In *Design Revolution: 100 Products That Empower People*, edited by E. Pilloton. London: Thames and Hudson.

Redfield, P. 2012. "Humanitarianism." In *A Companion to Moral Anthropology*, edited by D. Fassin, 449–467. Chichester, West Sussex: John Wiley & Sons.

Redfield, P. 2013. *Life in Crisis: The Ethical Journey of Doctors without Borders*. Berkely: University of California Press.

Redfield, P. 2018a. "On Band-Aids and Magic Bullets." *Limn*, 9. https://escholarship.org/uc/item/3jb6t31x.

Reid-Henry, S. M. 2014. "Humanitarianism as Liberal Diagnostic: Humanitarian Reason and the Political Rationalities of the Liberal Will-to-Care." *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 39 (3): 418–431. https://doi.org/10.1111/tran.12029.

Rosner, D. K. 2018. *Critical Fabulations: Reworking the Methods and Margins of Design*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Roth, S. 2015. *The Paradoxes of Aid Work: Passionate Professionals*. London: Routledge.

Said, E. W. 1989. "Representing the Colonized: Anthropology's Interlocutors." *Critical Inquiry* 15 (2): 205–225. https://doi.org/10.1086/448481.

Sandvik, K. B. 2017. "Now is the Time to Deliver: Looking for Humanitarian Innovation's Theory of Change." *Journal of International Humanitarian Action* 2 (1): 1–11. https://doi.org/10.1186/s41018-017-0023-2.

Scott-Smith, T. 2016. "Humanitarian Neophilia: The 'Innovation Turn' and Its Implications." *Third World Quarterly* 37 (12): 2229–2251. https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2016.1176856.

Seuferling, P., and K. Leurs. 2021. "Histories of Humanitarian Technophilia: How Imaginaries of Media Technologies Have Shaped Migration Infrastructures." *Mobilities* 16 (5): 670–687. https://doi.org/10.1080/17450101.2021.1960186.

Simon, H. A. 1969. *The Sciences of the Artificial*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Smirl, L. 2015. *Spaces of Aid: How Cars, Compounds and Hotels Shape Humanitarianism*. London: Bloomsbury Publishing.

Smith, Y., A. Craney, and C. Roche. 2024. "Racism, Colonialism and Whiteness in Development: Insights from Pacific Professionals Following Repatriation of White Staff during Covid-19." *Third World Quarterly* 45 (9): 1517–1535. https://doi.org/10.1080/01436597.2024.2356608.

Taylor, C. 2004. *Modern Social Imaginaries*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Ticktin, M. 2011. *Casualties of Care: Immigration and the Politics of Humanitarianism in France*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Ticktin, M. 2025. *Against Innocence: Undoing and Remaking the World*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

UNHCR. 2012. "Core Relief Items Catalogue." *United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees*. Accessed 24 June 2025. https://sheltercluster.org/resources/documents/unhcr-core-relief-items-catalogue.

Weizman, E. 2011. *Least of All Possible Evils: Humanitarian Violence from Arendt to Gaza*. London: Verso.

White, S. C. 2002. "Thinking Race, Thinking Development." *Third World Quarterly* 23 (3): 407–419. https://doi.org/10.1080/01436590220138358.

Williams, L. 2019. "The Co-Constitutive Nature of Neoliberalism, Design, and Racism." *Design and Culture* 11 (3): 301–321. https://doi.org/10.1080/17547075.2019.1656901.

Wilson, K. 2013. *Race, Racism and Development: Interrogating History, Discourse and Practice*. London: Bloomsbury Publishing.

Wilson Gilmore, R. 2022. *Abolition Geography: Essays Towards Liberation*. London: Verso.

Wynter, S. 1995. "1492: A New World View." In *Race, Discourse, and the Origin of the Americas: A New World View*, edited by V. L. Hyatt and R. Nettleford, 5–57. Washington: Smithsonian Institution Press.

Wynter, S. 1996. "Is Development a Purely Empirical Concept or Also Teleological? A Perspective from We the Underdeveloped." In *Prospects for Recovery and Sustainable Development in Africa*, edited by A. Yansané, 299–316. Westport, CT: Greenwood Press.

Wynter, S. 2003. "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom: Towards the Human, after Man, Its Overrepresentation – An Argument." *CR: The New Centennial Review* 3 (3): 257–337. https://doi.org/10.1353/ncr.2004.0015.

Wynter, S., and K. McKittrick. 2015. "Unparalleled Catastrophe for Our Species? Or, to Give Humanness a Different Future: Conversations." In *Sylvia Wynter: On Being Human as Praxis*, edited by K. McKittrick, 9–98. Durham: Duke University Press.

Ziadah, R. 2019. "Circulating Power: Humanitarian Logistics, Militarism, and the United Arab Emirates." *Antipode* 51 (5): 1684–1702. https://doi.org/10.1111/anti.12547.